Gursharan Singh, the Punjab batsman who later played a Test match for India against New Zealand in 1990.

Gursharan had fractured his finger while batting against the bowling of Atul Wassan, a Delhi fast bowler who also made his debut for India against New Zealand in 1990. He was sitting in the dressing room injured and there seemed to be no way he could play a further part in the match. I was batting well and was unbeaten on 86 when our ninth wicket fell. Knowing that Gursharan couldn't bat, I started walking back to the dressing room, assuming it was the end of our innings. Just then I saw Gursharan walking towards me, ready to bat one-handed.

It was later revealed to me that Raj Singh Dungarpur, then chairman of the national selection committee, had asked if he would go out and help me get to my hundred. In an exemplary show of courage, Gursharan had agreed. In fact, when we met at the wicket I felt distinctly embarrassed seeing him there in such severe pain. I told him that it would be perfectly understandable if we called off the innings. Showing tremendous grit, he told me, '*Ab to tera hundred kar ke hi jayenge.*' (I will get back to the pavilion only after you get your hundred.) He doggedly stuck to his task, and I'm glad to say that his bravery was respected by the opposition bowlers, who did not resort to bowling bouncers.

It was a favour I would never forget. It was a show of remarkable resilience by Gursharan and I tried to repay the debt by doing what I could at the time of his benefit match in Delhi in April 2005. I had promised him that as long as he gave me a few days' notice, I'd turn up to play, no matter where I was. I am glad I was able to keep my promise.

India in Pakistan, November–December 1989

Encouraged at having got a hundred against India's domestic champions, I headed to Pakistan soon after feeling reasonably confident. Maybe because I was still a teenager, I didn't feel any extra pressure about playing against Pakistan. The whole political baggage of India–Pakistan cricket meant nothing to me. I was simply treating it as my first tour, which was challenge enough. In any case, no one really expected me to be a part of the playing XI at such a young age, certainly not in any of the Tests. Some thought I might get a chance in one of the one-day games, depending on the team's performance in the series, while others believed I was there only to get a feel of international cricket.